Unit–9

COLLABORATION BETWEEN SCHOOL AND COMMUNITY

Written by:
Mahvish Naseem

Reviewed by:
Dr. Muhammad Tanveer Afzal

CONTENTS

S.No	Description	Page No
	Introduction	**183**
	Objectives	**183**
9.1	**Community Development Theory**	**184**
	9.1.1 Formulation of Objectives for Community School Collaboration	189
	9.1.2 Selection of Representatives for Collaboration	191
	9.1.3 Collaboration with Local Bodies	192
9.2	**Identification of Role and Responsibilities of Partners**	**192**
9.3	**Parent Teacher Meeting**	**194**
	9.3.1 Allocation of Time for Parent Teacher Meetings	198
9.4	**Mechanism to Promote Communication**	**200**
	9.4.1 Overcoming Linguistic Barriers	204
9.5	**Self-Assessment Questions**	**205**
9.6	**Suggested Readings**	**206**

INTRODUCTION

Schools have long recognized that they have a role in supporting young people's wider development, of which educational attainment is a critically important part.

The guidance notes that excellent teaching and learning to unlock the potential of every child must continue to be the core business of schools, on which they have the lead role. But schools can and do also make a significant contribution to other aspects of development, both because these are important in their own right for a good childhood and because they impact on children's ability to learn and develop.

Schools as the universal service for children and their families are uniquely well-placed to contribute to all aspects of their development, working with parents and with other services. The school without compromising on its core mission of educating children to their full potential contributes with others to all aspects of a child's social development, with a focus on early identification and prevention.

School-community collaboration occurs when groups or agencies come together to establish an educative community. The educative community is composed of a group of educating bodies such as school, home, places of worship, the media, museums, libraries, and community agencies. Everyone in the community is accountable for the quality of education.

There are seven characteristics of successful collaborations: shared vision, skilled leadership, process orientation, cultural diversity, membership-driven agenda, multiple sector representatives, and accountability. Some common barriers to collaboration are differences in philosophies, organizational cultures, and operating practices. These characteristics plays important role in building collaboration between school and community.

OBJECTIVES

After reading this lesson, students will be able to:

1. describe how to formulate objectives for effective community school collaboration
2. define how to develop yearly plans for community school collaboration and collaborate with local bodies;
3. identify the roles and responsibilities of partners in community development;
4. identify the steps to prepare for a group conference;
5. identify barriers and roadblocks for a successful parent teacher conference;
6. develop strategies for a positive parent teacher conference
7. recognize the strategies to overcome linguistic barriers

9.1 Community Development Theory

Since the late nineteenth century, the use of the term community has remained to some extent associated with the hope and the wish of reviving once more the closer, warmer, more harmonious type of bonds between people ambiguously attributed to past ages. Before 1910 there was little social science literature concerning 'community' and it was really only in 1915 that the first clear sociological definition emerged. This was coined by C. J. Galpin in relation to defining rural communities in terms of the trade and service areas surrounding a central village. A number of competing definitions of community quickly followed. Some focused on community as a geographical area; some on a group of people living in a particular place; and others which looked to community as an area of common life.

Beyond this there are issues around the way 'community' appears in political dialogue. For some it might mean little more than a glorified reworking of the market. For others, it may be a powerful organizing ideal. Here we will focus on understandings within social theory and will focus on collaboration between school and community.

Approaching the Theory of Community

It is helpful to begin by noting that community can be approached as a value. As such it may well be used to bring together a number of elements, for example, solidarity, commitment, mutuality and trust. Community can be approached as a descriptive category or set of variables. Initially community can be explored in three different ways.

1) **Place:** Territorial or place community can be seen as where people have something in common, and this shared element is understood geographically. Another way of naming this is as 'locality'.
2) **Interest:** In interest or 'elective' communities people share a common characteristic other than place. They are linked together by factors such as religious belief, occupation or ethnic origin. In this way we may talk about the 'Muslim community' or the 'Hindu community'.
3) **Communion:** In its weakest form we can approach this as a sense of attachment to a place, group or idea (in other words, whether there is a 'spirit of community'). In its strongest form 'communion' entails a profound meeting or encounter not just with other people, but also with God and creation.

There is, of course, a strong possibility that these different ways of approaching community will also overlap in particular instances. Place and interest communities may well coincide, for example in the case of places where many of those who live there work in the same industry. It is legitimate to add a third understanding of community that of attachment as communities of place or interest may not have a sense of shared identity.

Communities are best approached as 'communities of meaning'. In other words, '"community" plays a crucial symbolic role in generating people's sense of belonging'. The reality of community lies in its members' perception of the vitality of its culture. "People construct community symbolically, making it a resource and source of meaning and a referent of their identity'.

Community as Network and Local Social System

It is a fact that people live close to one another does not necessarily mean that they have much to do with each other. There may be little interaction between neighbours. It is the nature of the relationships between people and the social networks of which they are a part that is often seen as one of the more significant aspects of 'community'.

When people are asked about what 'community' means to them, it is such networks that are most commonly cited. 'For most of us, our deepest sense of belonging is to our most intimate social networks, especially family and friends. Beyond that perimeter lie work, religious places, neighbourhood, civic life, and a group of others. Wenger identified five types of support networks:

- ***the local family-dependent support network*.** This mainly relied on close kin, who often shared a household or lived locally.
- ***the locally integrated support network*.** This typically consisted of local family, friends and neighbours.
- ***the local self-contained support network*.** Usually restricted in scale and containing mainly neighbours, this form had relatively little kin involvement.
- ***the wider community-focused support network*.** Involving a high level of community activities, this form also typically entailed a high number of friends and kin.
- ***the private restricted support network*.** Characterized by an absence of close kin, aside from a spouse in some cases, this 'type' also meant few friends or neighbours.

The nature of the networks within in particular place or grouping is, thus, of fundamental importance when making judgments about 'communities' and the extent to which people can flourish within them. Humans are social animals. Connection and interaction both widen and deepen what we can achieve, and makes possible our individual character.

There are strong forces working against the formation and health of local social systems. Increasingly we operate across significant distances (for example, via letters, the telephone and the internet) when dealing with financial matters such as banking, shopping and the payment of bills. The various forces linked to globalization have led to significant shifts in the locus of power.

Activity:
Think of your family, friends and neighbours and discuss the nature of relationship with these groups and how you as a member of community can make the relationship stronger.

Community Norms and Habits

Whether people are willing to engage with one another is dependent upon the norms of a particular society or community and the extent to which individuals make them what de Tocqueville (1994), called it 'habits of the heart. To judge the quality of life within a particular community we, need to explore what shared expectations there are about the way people should behave and whether different individuals take these on. Three linked

qualities appear with some regularity in discussions of communal life:

Tolerance: openness to others; curiosity; perhaps even respect, a willingness to listen and learn.

Reciprocity: Putnam (2000) describes generalized reciprocity thus: 'I'll do this for you now, without expecting anything immediately in return, and perhaps without even knowing you, confident that down the road you or someone else will return the favour'. In the short run there is altruism, in the long run self-interest.

Trust: the confident expectation that people, institutions and things will act in a consistent, honest and appropriate way (or more accurately, 'trustworthiness' – reliability) is essential if communities are to flourish. Closely linked to norms of reciprocity and networks of civic engagement (Putnam 1993; Coleman 1990), social trust – trust in other people – allows people to cooperate and to develop. Trusting others does not entail us suspending our critical judgment – some people will be worthy of trust, some will not.

One of the fascinating things about these qualities is that in a very important sense such expectations do not need to be imposed upon people. As Matt Ridley (1997) put it, 'Our minds have been built by selfish genes, but they have been built to be social, trustworthy and cooperative'. He continues:

Humans have social instincts. They come into the world equipped with tendencies to learn how to cooperate, to discriminate the trustworthy from the treacherous, to commit themselves to be trustworthy, to earn good reputations, to exchange goods and information, and to divide labour… Far from being a universal feature of animal life, as Kropotkin believed, this instinctive cooperativeness is the very hallmark of humanity and what sets us apart from other animals. (Ridley, 1997)

To this extent, the cultivation of reciprocity, honesty and trust is less about building alien institutions and structures, than creating the conditions for their emergence. Self-interest may bring people together, but in interaction something else emerges. 'Feelings and ideas are renewed, the heart enlarged, and the understanding developed, only by the reciprocal action of men one upon another'.

Social Capital

A sense of belonging and the concrete experience of social networks (and the relationships of trust etc. that are involved) can bring significant benefits. However, the sense of attachment and quality of social networks varies greatly between the different 'communities' that people name.

The notion of social capital is a useful way of entering into debates about civil society whereas physical capital refers to physical objects and human capital refers to the properties of individuals, social capital refers to connections among individuals – social

networks and the norms of reciprocity and trustworthiness that arise from them. In that sense social capital is closely related to what some have called "civic virtue." The difference is that "social capital" calls attention to the fact that civic virtue is most powerful when embedded in a sense network of reciprocal social relations. A society of many virtuous but isolated individuals is not necessarily rich in social capital. In other words, interaction enables people to build communities, to commit themselves to each other, and to knit the social fabric.

Child Development is powerfully shaped by social capital. Trust, networks, and norms of reciprocity within a child's family, school, peer group, and larger community have far reaching effects on their opportunities and choices, and hence on their behaviour and development.

Public Spaces in high social-capital areas are cleaner, people are friendlier, and the streets are safer. Traditional neighbourhood "risk factors" such as high poverty and residential mobility are not as significant as most people assume. Places have higher crime rates in large part because people don't participate in community organizations, don't supervise younger people, and aren't linked through networks of friends.

Economic Prosperity: A growing body of research suggests that where trust and social networks flourish, individuals, firms, neighbourhoods, and even nations prosper economically. Social capital can help to mitigate the insidious effects of socioeconomic disadvantage.

Relationship between Education and Society

We have seen education in particular as a means of cultural transmission from one generation to another. The parents are the first teachers of the child and they still maintain an educative function throughout the early and formative years of the child. In most of the developing nations of the world, including Pakistan, parents are responsible for sending their children to school. Since these nations are undergoing rapid socioeconomic and political changes, they witness special problems in evolving the appropriate education system, which will be able to produce the adequate manpower needs in all the segments of the society.

Schools are established in many societies of the world so as to instill in the pupils those skill's which will afford them the opportunity of taking their rightful positions in the society; but this function cannot be adequately accomplished without the assistance of the home because both the home and the school perform complimentary functions in the moral and intellectual development of the child. This means that the child cannot be educated in a vacuum or in isolation. Therefore, for a child to be educated there must be interaction between him and his physical and social environment. By this we mean that education is the development of personality. It is something which goes on both inside and outside the home and in the school. In other words, education is an activity of the whole community.

This means that education is used in the transmission of the cultural values. One important implication of looking at education as the transmitter of cultural values is the fact that education can be influenced by the culture of the society in which it takes place. For this reason, one may infer that for a child to be educated, he must be influenced by his environment and, in turn, be capable of influencing it. And it is only by the concept of the continuous interaction of the individual and his society that the development of personality can be properly understood. Education is a mean through which the cultural values of a particular society are transmitted from one generation to another. Through this process, the society is able to achieve basic social conformity and ensure that its traditional values, beliefs, attitudes and aspirations are maintained and preserved. Clarks (1948) observed that a general knowledge and acceptance of the ideals and aims of our society is essential for all its citizens, and it must be achieved through education but in a form, which makes it compatible with freedom. A society needs a stable and dynamic set of values and a, unified purpose. It is when this is determined that meaningful economic, political and social programmes can be embarked upon for the overall benefits of the citizens. To be a fully developed person in such a society implies full and creative membership of it with powers to change it.

Education depends on the total way of life of a people in a society. This suggests that the type of education provided will differ from society to society. Besides, each society has its own norms, values and its own ideal persons who stand out clearly for the younger generations to follow. Since all these societies are not the same, then it means that a man regarded as a hero in one society because of his contributions to educational development of the society may not be regarded as such in another society where education is not given priority in the scheme of their daily activities. It, therefore, implies that children have different people to emulate in different societies. It is logical to expect that the type education given in each society will change from time to time as the society changes. Many writers have argued that education is one of the causes of social change in the society, but another school of thought is of the opinion, that educational change tends to follow other social changes, rather than initiate them. Exceptional individuals invent new techniques and propound new values for their society. These ideas arise from the impact of human beings on their culture, but do not change the culture until they are shared and transmitted by a social group.

Another area of the relationship between education and society is through the arrangement of the entire society into a hierarchical order that is, through the social structure in which education plays a prominent and significant role in fixing educated individuals into social classes. Ottaway (1980) observed that education is the process of preparing people to fit into this complex social structure and to play particular social roles as members of more than one institutional group. Individuals have to learn to be fathers or mothers, school teachers or civil servants, shopkeepers or priests. They have to learn to keep the law, to understand how they are governed and to be prepared to try and change the social moves when they see that they can be improved.

Education as a social phenomenon is also concerned with the preparation of the child for his future occupation in life. This is one of the main economic functions of education and this is in the interest of both the nation and the individual. Through education an individual knows the structure of the society and the different types of relationships that exist among those structures in the society. The child is taught how to perform different roles within the social structure in the society. These roles are inter-related. For example, the role of a father is a relational role; a father could be a son to, another person. So education allows the child to perform his role adequately within the social structure in the society. In addition, the child is able to understand the networks of inter-relationships among the different social institutions that make up the society. Like an individual, each institution has definite functions to perform in the society and the functions of each institution differ from one to another even though they are complimentary. Another aspect of the relationship between education and society is in the area of social interaction. Social interaction may be defined as any relation between people and groups, which changes the behaviour of the people in the group. There is a need for social interaction by the child before he could acquire the culture of his society. This interaction in the society is therefore part of the child's education, provided that, that type of interaction brings about positive changes in the child's behaviour in a right direction as required by the educational system. One important point here is that the child has been taking part in group interaction long before he starts to attend school and the most common among these group interactions are within the family and the peer group. These groups in which the child interacts give him the opportunity to learn from the wider circles in the society. From his social contacts, he learns his roles in different groups and this influences his personality development.

Activity:
Discuss in your groups “what do you practice to make school and community relationship stronger as a prospective teacher?” share your reflections with others.

9.1.1 Formulation of Objectives for Community School Collaboration

Schools do not exist in isolation and they cannot go it alone. To keep students in school their social, economic, and family needs, as well as their academic needs must be met. They need the support and help of the whole community. The often heard statement, "It takes a village to raise a child," is very true. Volunteers and funding are two major ways that communities support their schools. Some of the initiatives that involve partnering with the community are School-to-Work Programmes, after-school centers, and parental involvement programmes. Coordinating community collaborations to avoid duplication and keeping them focused on a common goal is a challenge.

Improving School-Community Collaboration by Formulating Objectives

There are a variety of activities in which schools can become involved to help improve school-community relations; below are some points:

1. **Encourage community use of school facilities**: Often the school building sits empty after the end of the normal school day. Encouraging non-profit community

groups to use the facilities is not only a good use of resources but also provides an opportunity for the school to put its best foot forward. Some schools have reported a reduction in destruction because of the various activities.

2. **Student Recognition:** Invite students who earned a place on the honour roll to an Honours Banquet; the banquet can be held at a local restaurant during school hours or in the evening. In many communities, restaurants may be willing to support a programme of this nature by providing meals at cost or even at reduced prices. Invite prominent people to speak at the banquet educational leaders, political leaders, business people; the list can be endless.
3. **Gold Cards**: give students who earn a place on the Honour Roll a Gold Card which is honoured by participating businesses who provide discounts to students for the marking period. Some businesses provide reduced prices on items in their stores while others allow students to have something for free, i.e., a free video rental.
4. **Honour Society:** make a determined effort to share the recognition of students by honouring them during the school day, with other students in attendance. Most parents are more than willing to come in during the day to participate in the ceremony. If it is not possible to have the ceremony during the day, have it in the evening but be sure to invite faculty, staff and students to attend.
5. **Honours Passes**: students who earn a place on the Honour Roll could receive an Honours Pass which allows them certain freedom of movement in the building. A list of guidelines can be developed and students can be asked to sign agreements to abide by these guidelines. We want to send the message that the students on the honour roll have demonstrated a commitment to academic excellence and have shown a maturity of judgment and an acceptance of responsibility that entitle them to more rights and privileges.
6. **Senior Citizens Banquet**: at least once a year, perhaps around the time of a music concert, invite senior citizens to a luncheon banquet at the school; the banquet, run with the cooperation of the school lunch programme, can be sponsored by a class, by a school service organization, or by the entire school, if it is small one. Parents have been very willing to come in to assist in the preparation of the meal. Prior to the banquet, invite the senior citizens to a dress rehearsal of the musical programme, since many senior citizens are reluctant to attend programmes in the evening.
7. **Senior Citizens Passes**: provide passes to area senior citizens to attend all school functions at no charge; while some will provide a donation in exchange for the ticket, many will appreciate the extra welcome provided by the school.
8. **Back to School Week**: choose a week during the school year to invite parents and community members to your school. Businesses have been more and more willing to provide release time to their employees for activities of this nature. Make a special effort to personally invite community and business leaders to attend school for the day, or part of the day.
9. **Honours Assemblies**: at the end of each marking period, hold an honours assembly at which students on the honour roll receive certificates, bumper stickers and gold cards for having earned a place on the Honour Roll.

10. **Student Recognition**: if a student performs exceptionally well, why not recognize that achievement? A short note from an administrator, mailed to the student, provides a significant boost in morale for the student.
11. **Career Day**: hold annual career days; not only this is a good educational experience for the students, it also helps local business people learn more about the school and our needs; conversely, it helps us understand the employment needs of business in our area.
12. **News Releases**: news releases mailed to local media can be helpful; publish things such as honour rolls, special class projects or activities, assemblies, school activities, etc.
13. **Newsletters**: provide periodic newsletters not only to the families of students but also to board members, business leaders, and other community members. A simple database can be used to include new people; encourage members of the school community so suggest other folks who might be included in the mailing list.
14. **Positive Reinforcement:** Faculty members should be encouraged to contact the families of students by phone or letter when the youngster has shown significant improvement or demonstrated positive qualities of behaviour. Administrators can also increase rapport with parents by contacting them when the youngster has done something well.

9.1.2 Selection of Representatives for Collaboration

A community representative must be a member of the community and can be a parent of a child in the school. Community representatives are appointed by school council members. A community representative brings an additional perspective to council decision.

As a member of the school council, the community representative:

- expresses the viewpoint of the community they represent;
- communicates the activities of the council to stakeholders;
- works collectively towards the common goal of improving teaching, learning and student achievement;
- participates in the school development process with other participants; and,
- participates in and is prepared for council meetings and discussions.

Parent/Guardian Representatives

Any parent/guardian can be a parent representative on the school. The parent representative: expresses the viewpoint of the parents they represent;

- communicates the activities of the council to the other parents;
- works collectively towards the common goal of improving teaching, learning and student achievement;
- participates in the school development process with other stakeholders; and,
- participates in and is prepared for council meetings and discussions.

Teacher Representatives

Teachers may serve as parent representatives on any school their children attend, provided they are not employed as a teacher at that school. The teacher representative:

- expresses the viewpoint of the teacher community they represent;
- communicates the activities of the council to the other teachers;
- works collectively towards the common goal of improving teaching, learning and student achievement;
- participates in the school development process with other stakeholders; and,
- participates in and is prepared for council meetings and discussions.

Activity:
Have a parent (also a teacher) on the panel who could speak for both the community of parents and teachers (have two male and female to both perspectives).

9.1.3 Collaboration with Local Bodies

An effective family-community-school collaboration must come together at the local level. Thus, a school and its surrounding community are a reasonable focal point around which to build an infrastructure. Primary emphasis on this level meshes nicely with contemporary restructuring views that stress increased school based and neighbourhood control. From a local perspective, first the focus is on mechanisms at the school-neighbourhood level. Based on analyses of what is needed to facilitate and enhance efforts at a locality, mechanisms are conceived that enable several school-neighbourhood collaborative to work together for increased efficiency, effectiveness, and economies of scale (e.g., connecting a complex or "family" of schools, such as a high school and its feeder schools). Then, system wide mechanisms can be (re)designed to provide support for what each locality is trying to develop. Developing an effective collaborative requires an infrastructure of organizational and operational mechanisms at all relevant levels for oversight, leadership, capacity building, and ongoing support. Such mechanisms are used to:

a) make decisions about priorities and resource allocation;
b) maximize systematic planning, implementation, maintenance, and evaluation;
c) enhance and redeploy existing resources and pursue new ones; and
d) nurture the collaborative. At each level, such tasks require pursuing an assertive agenda.

9.2 Identification of Role and Responsibilities of Partners

'Two heads are better than one' is really true when it comes to strengthening children and families in a holistic way. By thinking, planning, and working together, the individuals and groups that make a community can accomplish goals that neither could achieve alone.

Diverse partners shape their holistic efforts through **collaborative partnerships**. These partnerships give communities a structure for organizing, planning, and implementing their ideas. Collaborative partnerships are the mechanism for designing **comprehensive strategies** that strengthen children and families.

The process of building a collaborative partnership is multidimensional. It involves:

- recognizing opportunities for change;
- mobilizing people and resources to create changes;
- developing a vision of long-term change;
- seeking support and involvement from diverse and non-traditional partners;
- choosing an effective group structure;
- building trust among collaborators; and
- developing learning opportunities for partners.

Although the effort takes time and requires careful attention, it is essential to create strong, workable partnerships that produce lasting change.

How Do Collaborative Efforts Get Started?

Comprehensive partnerships begin because individuals reach out to like-minded people and groups to address issues that affect children and families.

There are many catalysts for comprehensive partnerships. Some form when school leaders or local policymakers initiate collaboration. Others begin when a community becomes aware of an urgent need for change, or when funding becomes available to respond to conditions in the community.

For example, a school superintendent notified of new public or private funds for comprehensive services, may work with teachers, parents, and community agencies to develop school-linked strategies for health care, adult education, child care, job preparation, and violence prevention programmes. Or, school staff may initiate collaboration with the community to respond to a recognized need:

In rural area, school staff learned of a developmentally delayed pre-school child whose parents had been unaware of the community services available to them but were willing to work with school, health, and human service providers to enroll the child in a pre-school programme. Agency staff formed a team to support the parents' efforts to work with their child at home. They also helped the father enroll in a job training programme. Encouraged by the success of this collaboration, the team decided to formalize its partnership in order to tackle similar issues.

Once an individual or small group of planners lights the spark of collaboration, school leaders join with families, community leaders and representatives, and health and human service providers to create individual programmes into comprehensive strategies. This core group evolves into a collaborative effort by:

1) understanding the context for collaboration,
2) expanding to include parents and other community partners,

3) forming a partnership, and
4) establishing an effective governance structure.

Forming a Partnership

While beginning partnership, it is necessary to attract appropriate participants to the collaborating table and that they can work effectively once they get there. Experienced partnerships offer the following role:

1. ***Ensure a broad based, inclusive partnership*** by seeking partners who represent a cross section of the community: parents, principals, teachers, councellors and other school staff, cultural and religious leaders, health care and human service providers, business and political leaders, staff and administrators from community organizations, and representatives from local universities and student groups. Partners should reflect diverse perspectives, experiences, cultures, and levels of authority.
2. ***Don't wait for all partners to get on board before moving forward*** with a plan. Most partnerships expand gradually over time. *For example*, in one community a partnership that focused on school linked strategies eventually joined forces with a partnership concerned with community policing. The joint effort, named "Peace Builders," built capacity for conflict resolution and supported community policing strategies. As the entire community gradually embraced the idea, the size and impact of the new partnership grew.
3. ***Secure a commitment to collaboration***. It is necessary that partner should designate representatives' names and responsibilities in writing; this makes it more likely the same people will be at the table every time the group meets.

Evolving collaborative partnerships often struggle between the desire to take immediate action and the need to plan for a sustained effort. There is no specific formula for how much time and energy to initially allocate for building relationships or for planning strategies, but experienced partnerships agree that both activities are essential to long-term success.

Activity:
Share how you think of developing interpersonal relationships between partners. Each group will make 5 minutes presentations.

9.3 Parent Teacher Meeting

Parent-teacher meetings are a regular feature of school life. Often they add to stress loads. Not only do they usually occur before or after a busy day of teaching, many teachers feel uncomfortable dealing with parents.

Communication with parents and guardians of students require considerable planning and effort on the teacher's part. One method will not work with all parents. Communication with families can be face-to-face, written or electronic. An opportunity for face-to-face verbal communication occurs at parent-teacher conferences. If run effectively, conferences can offer great opportunities to establish good relationships, but if handled poorly, they can have negative consequences.

Setting up the environment for the interviews is important. Schools should have a clear space to meet with the parents. Wherever possible, avoid setting up a table between teacher and the parent. Ideally teacher should be seated alongside the parent so that discussion can be made properly.

Tips for a Successful Parent-Teacher Conference

Following are some tips for teachers:

1. It is important to ensure the space is private and that conversations can be held confidentially. A clearly signposted waiting area should be provided for parents. Provide waiting parents with a folder of their child's work samples or a list of questions they might like to reflect on. Identify key points and issues to discuss. Use appropriate work samples to illustrate key messages.
2. It is important to stick to the designated appointment times. If a longer period of time is likely to be needed, book a double block of time. If the allocated time has been utilized and there are more issues to be discussed, make another appointment.
3. Always begin the meeting with something positive about the student. Many teachers find the **'sandwich approach'** helpful. Start with a positive, discuss areas where improvements can be made and close with a positive statement. Parents want to know that teacher know and care about their child, even if there are challenges.
4. It is essential that the meetings should be held in clear, fair and transparent are honest and clear. The Stephen Covey term **'Talk straight'** is particularly relevant to Parent-Teacher meetings. It is important to ensure that teacher is not **'sugar coating'** things too much to avoid confrontation or being too blunt and thereby causing offence. Parents need to be given accurate information. However, teachers also need to phrase things carefully so that they are not seen as criticizing their parenting. Getting the balance right ensures that at the conclusion of the meeting the parent has received the clear message that the teacher had intended.
5. The intention of Parent-Teacher meetings should always be for both parties to share information about the student. The aim should be for both parties to have a better (hopefully shared) understanding of the student. It is therefore important to listen as well as give information to parents. Teacher should ask if they have any information that he/she should be aware of.
6. Avoid meetings becoming a **'point scoring'** event. The meetings are NOT about who is right and who is wrong. They are about building up a partnership to assist

the student. Teacher should give some thought to know that how parents of this particular student could assist them at home?

7. At the end of the session, teacher should summarize with the help of parent, the plans or commitments that have been made and agree on the timeline. S/he should allow time in his/her schedule to jot down some notes of the key points and any commitments made.

Following are some tips for parents for a successful Parent-Teacher Conference:

1. Develop five questions specific to the child
2. Ask your child if there is anything that he would like you to discuss with the teacher.
3. Make a list of positives and negatives aspects that your child is having.
4. Arrive promptly or a few minutes early.
5. Introduce yourself to the teacher, and let the teacher know where you can be reached.
6. Ask questions. What is the class going to cover this year, and how can I help? What can we do at home to help?
7. Say a few words about your child's special interests and positive qualities, but you don't have to go into every dark secret. Your child may behave differently with this teacher; talking about negative qualities at this stage could put those expectations in a new teacher's mind. Avoid lengthy discussions of topics that are not related to the purpose of the conference.
8. Keep your emotions under control and be open-minded to suggestions from the teacher. Take notes about what has been discussed to share with your child.
9. Volunteer to help out. Let the teacher and the principal know when you are available. You could help organizer of a field trip, read to kids for an hour a week, or print the class newsletter on your home computer. But don't bite off more than you really have time for. Be consistent. Be someone the teacher can count on. Do not stay beyond your allotted time.

Activity:
Keeping in view the tips for successful parent teacher meeting arrange a mock parent teacher conference addressing communication barriers that parents and teachers face.

Dos and Don'ts for Parent Teacher Conference

Every new member should know for parent teacher meetings

Dos	Don'ts
1. Always greet parents warmly at the door. Plan and create an inviting environment. Accompany parents to the place where meeting will be held.	Don't summon parents into the classroom and direct them to sit in front of desk. Parents may be anxious or fearful about meeting with the you, as it is key authority figure in their child's life.
2. Start the meeting by showing that you care and know something positive about their child. Summarize the student's strengths before raising problems. Of course, if you have a heavy student load, it can be hard to get to know each child well by early fall conferences.	Don't begin by focusing on the student's problems.
3. Dress in a way that reflects the meeting's importance and your respect for the parents and their child.	Don't dress too casually for the occasion. Some people think casual dress will make the parent feel more comfortable, but experts say that can backfire. You are a professional, and professional dress communicates that message.
4. Rehearse what you want to say. Practice warm up introductions, prepare an outline, and prepare a checklist of areas to cover. Plan how you will keep track of time.	Don't wing it.
5. Use materials from the student's work folder. It is much easier to demonstrate progress or show parents concretely what a student needs to do to improve if you utilize these materials.	Don't rely on verbal descriptions of the student's work and progress. Avoid subjective statements such as "His conduct is bad." Instead, cite specifics such as: "She talks out of turn," or, "He won't sit in his seat."
6. Use positive, nonverbal behaviour. Listen reflectively. Maintain good eye contact. Lean in when you speak or make suggestions.	Don't point a finger at parents or place blame.
7. Engage parents in planning best ways to help their child. Seek their suggestions first.	Don't dominate a meeting so that parents can't ask questions or make suggestions. There's so much you want to tell them, but think hard about how much information parents need. Parents are most interested in specifics related to their child and will almost always have concerns or questions of their own.

8. Do give parents something to take home with them. They can review material more completely at home and refer back to it during the year. This can also save time at the conference.	Don't send them home empty handed.
9. Use clear and descriptive terms. Adjust to the parents' needs and levels of understanding.	Don't use education jargon or acronyms. This can have a chilling effect on parent communications. Some common buzzwords that you know but parents might not include whole language, math manipulatives, SATs, ACTs, IEPs, paradigm, inclusion and cooperative learning.
10. Do end positively, with a proactive message of hope. Set goals. Review how parents can help. Mention plans for follow through. Let parents know their support is needed and appreciated. If appropriate, send a follow-up letter.	Don't end the meeting on a negative note by recounting the problem.

Activity:
Quickly write
Participants will write for two minutes about what they think are characteristics of successful parent/teacher conference.

9.3.1 Allocation of Time for Parent Teacher Meetings

Allocation of time for parent teacher meeting requires careful planning and planning is necessary productive and successful meeting.

Planning for Parent Teacher Meeting

As with teaching, planning is critical to an effective meeting. Here are some important steps to include:

1. Prepare a send-home that invites parents for meeting, states the purpose of the meeting, and lists potential times, including both afternoon and evening slots. Have parents call or send a note to reserve a time slot.
2. Prepare an agenda that you as teacher wants share with parents before the meeting. Include such topics as general impression of the child, his or her progress in each academic area, test scores, goals for the child in each content area, and strategies you will use to meet goals.
3. Plan (and write down) questions to ask, points to make, and suggestions to offer.
4. Ask parents to bring to the conference a list of their child's strengths and weaknesses as they perceive them.
5. Listing the child's strengths and weaknesses and propose action to be taken.
6. Collect samples of student work to display.

7. Prepare to explain your goals and teaching strategies.
8. Schedule enough time for questions and discussion.
9. Pull together necessary materials such as a daily schedule of classroom activities, a checklist of skill areas and notes on student progress, sample work, test scores, and reports from other teachers where appropriate.

Planning for Parent Teacher Meeting on Part of Parents

A conference with child's teacher is similar to a visit to the doctor's office. Parents have a lot that they want to talk about, and a limited amount of time. The better prepared parents are going in, the more beneficial the meeting will be for both parent and the teacher. Here are some tips for a productive parent/teacher conference.

Steps to Take Before the Conference

1. **Schedule appointment early:** Parents need to get a time before meeting that will work well for them. If possible, both the parents should go to the conference together. This lets the teacher know that both of them are involved in their child's education. And parents can compare notes on what they heard and talk over how to deal with the information when they get home.

2. **Knowledge about child's progress at school:** Before the conference parents should ask from the child some very specific questions about school. What would he/she like them to ask the teacher? What does he/she like best about school? Are there any subjects at school that he/she is having trouble with? If he/she could change anything about school what would it be?

3. **Write down the questions:** Once parents are in a meeting with the teacher, it may be hard to remember what they wanted to talk about. Jot down the questions beforehand and bring them to the conference.

How to Make the Conference Time

1. **Stick to talking about the child:** Most parent/teacher conferences last only for 20 minutes. They shouldn't use this time to ask questions about basic school policies. That kind of information can usually be found in the school's handbook, on its Web site, or by calling the office during working hours. This is a chance to get detailed feedback on child, so grab it. If the parents have a specific question or issue that doesn't come up, they should not hesitate to ask. The teacher may be inexperienced or shy, or just not realize that the parents are concerned about a particular thing.

2. **Establish a rapport with the teacher:** The first parent/teacher conference is a chance to get to know the teacher. If they can make a connection early in the year, it will be easier to talk to the teacher in the future about any questions or concerns. To get off on the right foot, first listen to what the teacher has to say, and then base your questions on what is said. You may also want to ask her something about herself, her teaching philosophy, etc. to get a better understanding of who she is.

3. **Try not to get defensive:** Every parent wants to hear how wonderful his or her child is and the teacher should tell you about your child's special skills and achievements. But one of the main functions of these conferences is to point out areas where your child has room to develop. The teacher may even suggest testing, special classes, or some change in your behaviour. Keep in mind that this is a part of all parent-teacher conferences.

4. **Take a notepad and pen:** After the meeting is over you may forget some of what you discussed. Jotting things down as you go along will help jog your memory later. Taking notes is also a good way to let the teacher know you're really paying attention.

5. **Give the teacher relevant information:** Let the teacher know of any changes at home. A new baby, a divorce, or a death in the family can all affect the way your child behaves in the classroom. Resist the urge to talk about his successes outside of school, though. As much fun as it is to tell cute stories, this meeting is about assessing your child's academic progress.

6. **When speaking to other teachers stick to their area of expertise:** If you have the opportunity to meet with your child's other teachers, limit your questions to their particular subject. Discuss art with the art teacher, reading with the reading expert and so on.

7. **Leave with an action plan:** Before you shake hands and say goodbye, find out the best way to follow-up with the teacher. Can you call her? Does she have an e-mail address you can use? You may think of other questions later so find out the best way to ask them. As you end the conference, review any decisions that you've made together. And if you feel it's necessary, request another meeting.

9.4 Mechanism to Promote Communication

Teachers attempt to establish partnerships with parents to support student learning. Strong communication is fundamental to this partnership and to build a sense of community between home and school. In these changing times, teachers must continue to develop and expand their skills in order to maximize effective communication with parents. Epstein describes communicating with parents as one of major type of parent involvement practices critical to establish strong working relationships between teachers and parents.

Avenues of Communication

Communication may involve impressions created or words expressed. In fact, communication begins with the welcome sign when the parent first enters the school building (Chambers, 1998). Welcome signs reflecting the range of languages spoken in the school community create an even more inviting atmosphere (Lai & Ishiyama, 2004). The next impression may be the smile or, conversely, lack of acknowledgement by office staff. Parents may also be positively influenced by the cleanliness of the school grounds,

student artwork on the walls, and the sounds in the corridors. A parent friendly school environment reflects how highly communication with parents is valued by the school.

Expressed communication involves one-way or two-way exchanges. ***One-way*** communication occurs when teachers seek to inform parents about events, activities, or student progress through a variety of sources, such as an introductory letter at the beginning of the school year, classroom or school newsletters, report cards, communication books, school web sites, and so on. ***Two-way*** communication involves interactive dialogue between teachers and parents. Conversations may occur during telephone calls, home visits, parent-teacher conferences, open houses, and various school-based community activities. Teachers should actively incorporate both strategies to maximize sharing information with parents.

One-Way Communication

"Written communication is probably the most efficient and effective way we can provide valuable ongoing correspondence between school and home" (Williams & Cartledge, 1997). Written communication is a permanent record between both the partners.

Two-Way Communication

Two-way communication occurs when teachers and parents dialogue together. Effective dialogue "develops out of a growing trust, a mutuality of concern, and an appreciation of contrasting perspectives" (Lawrence-Lightfoot, 2004). A teacher may contact parents to celebrate a child's successful school experience.

However, more frequently, the contact is to share a concern about the child, which can be a source of significant tension for both teachers and parents alike. Teachers should strive to make these interactions as productive as possible.

Phone calls: One popular communication strategy is a phone call at home. It is the best way to contact the teacher. Making the initial phone call will open the lines of communication with teachers. Love (1996) advocates the use of "good news calls" to recognize the child for progress or a job well done as a way of promoting positive relations with parents. By keeping calls brief and leaving messages as needed.

As the teacher of a multi-age class, Gustafson (1998) called the parents of each child in her class monthly to discuss concerns or to answer questions. She noted that these contacts provided her with valuable information about the lives of her students, including extracurricular activities, bullying experiences, and a death in the family. Gustafson concluded that the solid academic performance of her students came, at least in part, from positive communication with parents by phone.

Parent Teacher Conference:
Another traditional occasion for dialogue is the parent-teacher conference. It can create a successful partnership so both parent and teachers are on the same page. Discussion can occur and avoid blame by taking a solution-focused approach. Effective parent-teacher conferences are an opportunity to create a successful partnership, but they may be anxiety provoking for both teachers and parents alike (Minke & Anderson, 2003). Follow-up after Parent-Teacher conferences helps to plan specific strategies if needed or discuss further with other teachers.

Activity:
Think of your student life experience and discuss the occasions when a conflict began between a parent and a teacher and how you or your teachers resolved it.

Barriers to Communication

Barriers that hinder good communication between educators and parents exist at several levels. **At a societal level**, Brandt (1998) notes that the public in general is becoming increasingly divided from public institutions, and schools are more frequently the target of negative reports. Additionally, Taffel (2001) notes that many parents today feel unsupported, misunderstood, and overwhelmed by the demands placed on them. To address these barriers, educators should appreciate that every positive interchange will serve to increase trust and build stronger relationships, not only with individual parents, but ultimately with the broader community as well. Local school needs to become a vibrant part of the community, and schools have the advantage of being a natural point of interaction with parents. As such, schools are in a position to host or facilitate workshops for parents on a variety of topics ranging from child development to stress management. Schools can help create support groups for parents to address a range of needs (Molland, 2004). Schools can also provide a mechanism for the involvement of community stakeholders to lead workshops, provide resource links for families fund and participate in school projects, and support mentorship programmes.

Cultural differences can create significant communication challenges if teachers use "their own cultural lenses" to interact with culturally and linguistically diverse parents (Colombo, 2004). To address this potential disconnect, teachers need to seek out information to understand the cultural and linguistic diversity reflected in the families of their students. This knowledge and appreciation can be demonstrated by celebrating the various cultural traditions of their students, by incorporating speakers from the community, by appreciating the difficulties faced by immigrant parents, and by seeking out interpreter services as needed (Lai & Ishiyama, 2004). Similarly, teachers can incorporate the faces of diversity into children's literature in the classroom (Molland, 2004).

Bilingual hotlines, as well as a bilingual phone tree, have been suggested as creative ways to enhance communication with culturally diverse families regarding upcoming events (Ramirez, 2001). Similarly, it may be appropriate to provide written communication in several languages to ensure the greatest access to the parent community.

However, knowledge regarding a culture is not sufficient according to Kasahara & Turnbull (2005). They noted that professionals must also to seek to understand the uniqueness of each family based on their own reality within their cultural milieu. Time and effort invested by teachers to research and better understand the cultures reflected in their school community can only serve to enhance partnership opportunities.

On a parental level, a parent's own negative school experiences may impact positive relationships with teachers, or parents may simply not understand how to effectively interact with the educational system. These barriers can become particularly problematic when such a parent is faced with concerns regarding their child's behaviour or academic progress. Schools can provide guidelines in a checklist format to assist parents in managing their concerns in a constructive manner (Hartman & Chesley, 1998). These guidelines would encourage parents to approach their concern from an information-gathering perspective, to start at the classroom level, to hear the teacher's perspective fully, and identify how and when to engage the principal. Providing such information to parents at back-to-school nights and in the school newsletter creates a proactive plan for parents to follow guidelines.

Economic and time constraints may also be primary obstacles to effective communication (Finders & Lewis, 1994). To address this, teachers can survey parents at the beginning of the school year to determine parent schedules and availability, and also to provide parents with information regarding how and when to contact the teacher. Meeting times need to be somewhat flexible to accommodate working parents, including those working shifts and those who commute.

Reaching out in the form of home visits may also be needed to connect with some families (Molland, 2004). Logistical constraints such as childcare and transportation create challenges for many parents (Geenen, Powers, & Lopez-Vasquez, 2001). Providing childcare options in the school building while parents attend meetings can make all the difference for some families.

Lack of technology also limits communication opportunities for many families. Teachers should never assume that students have access to technology at home (Ramirez, 2001). They should survey parents regarding access to voice mail, computers, and the internet. In addition, many teachers and parents are still uncomfortable with the use of technology.

Thus, Ramirez noted that "paper-based" communication should still have a fundamental place in the overall communication strategy of the school, despite extensive technology use.

Importantly, the rules to written communication also apply to e-mail and web based content, and confidentiality of personal information must be ensured. On a school level, the use of educational jargon with parents is a common communication roadblock. Teachers should monitor their conversation and written communications to ensure jargon is avoided. If technical terms or acronyms must be used, these should be carefully explained. Audio messages may be appropriate to communicate with parents who have reduced literacy levels (Williams & Cartledge, 1997).

Finally, a significant barrier may be the ***still traditional 5-15 minute parent conference*** that offers little time for meaningful communication regarding a child's academic and social progress. The perception that the teacher holds the "official evidence" of student achievement may further hinder a parent's active participation (Nichols & Read, 2002). To address this, Nichols and Read suggest that teachers set the stage for an effective interview by providing parents with work samples in the weeks preceding the conference; these samples should be accompanied by information explaining the task and any assistance or accommodations the student received. Parent-teacher meeting can also become a more effective interchange when parents feel invited and encouraged to attend, when conferences are well planned, and when teachers have identified the main points to be discussed with samples of the child's work at hand (Stevens & Tollafield, 2003). Effective use of communications skills, inviting the valuable insights of parents, and developing a reasonable plan reflecting the perspectives of the various participants all serve to make conferences as comfortable and productive as possible (Stevens & Tollafield). Finally, depending on the circumstance and goal, the child's presence at the conference may or may not enhance communication with parents (Potter & Bulach, 2001). Whether or not to include the child may require thoughtful consideration.

9.4.1 Overcoming Linguistic Barriers

There are many different ways of communication between living beings, spoken and written language is the most common way and the basic tool used for communication between human beings.

As a result of the geographic distribution of the origin of people, each one of them has developed its own linguistic code, which later on became an obstacle when they started to move beyond their boundaries seeking integration with other people. The differences between the various linguistic codes, in terms of spoken language as well as written representation, configure a barrier for communication and integration of people from different regions.

Challenging these barriers, it is noticeable an ever more intense movement towards integration. The huge technological progress reached by the human being, especially in air transport and in telecommunications, has accelerated the globalization process and it is turning more and more frequent the interaction between representatives of different people and different cultures.

The barrier of linguistic differences has an important impact on the efficiency of cultural, scientific, technological and commercial interchange; that is why it has grown so dramatically the demand for learning foreign languages. Otherwise, the great potential of information technology started to be exploited in order to help people to overcome the barrier of linguistic differences and a number of automatic translation tools have come out.

Language barriers are a common challenge in school settings and a two-way process. What speakers often don't realize is that frequently it is not the other person's accent but their *own way of speaking* that creates the greatest barriers to effective communication. Use the strategies below to ensure you're not putting up your own roadblocks to effective communication.

1. **Speak Slowly and Clearly**
   Focus on clearly enunciating and slowing down your speech. Even if you are pressured for time, do not rush through your communication. Doing so often takes more time, as miscommunication and misunderstanding can result and you will ultimately have to spend additional time in clearing up the confusion.

2. **Ask for Clarification**
   If you are not 100% sure you have understood what others say, politely ask for clarification. Avoid assuming you have understood what's been said.

3. **Avoid Idioms**
   Language is often contextual, and therefore culture specific. As a good general rule, if the phrase requires knowledge of other information be it a game or metaphor; recognize that this may make your communication more difficult to be understood.

4. **Avoid Slang Language**
   Watch the use of TLAs (Three Letter Abbreviations) and other organizational language that may not be understood by parents and other community members. If you use them, provide in parentheses a description of what these are so others can learn to use the same language you do.

5. Be Specific

Spell out your expectations clearly. Instead of, 'Please get back to me shortly,' say 'Please meet me or report by 1 pm on Wednesday, February 21.'

6. Choose your Medium of Communication Effectively

Carefully choose your form of communication (face to face meeting, phone or email, instant message, etc.). Be mindful not to 'overuse' written. While useful, there are times when the medium is likely to be ineffective. When a message is complex and complicated or there is tension or conflict that needs to be resolved, switch to another medium.

7. Be Patient

Cross cultural communication takes more time. If not at all times, certainly initially you cannot expect your communication to occur with the same speed and ease as when you are communicating with someone from your own culture.

9.5 Self-Assessment Questions

1. How School-Community Collaboration can be improved by formulating objectives?
2. What steps you should consider as a prospective teacher for Parent Teacher Meeting?
3. What is 'Sandwich Approach'? How it helps a teacher during Parent Teacher Meeting?
4. What are some strategies for effective communication between parents and teachers?
5. What are the types of communication?

9.6 Suggested Readings

Collaboration between School and Community. http://www.communitydevelopment.com.au/Documents/Understanding%20Community%20Development.pdf

Aronson, M. M. (1995). Building Communication Partnerships with Parents. Westminster, CA: Teacher Created Materials, Inc.

King , S. H. & Goodwin, A.L. (2002). Culturally Responsive Parental Involvement: Concrete Understandings and Basic Strategies. American Association of Colleges for Teacher Education: U.S.A.

Parent/teacher relations. (2009). Retrieved from http://www.teachervision.fen.com/education-and-parents/resource/4549.html

Zeiger, J. (2007). Teacher Guide: How to Effectively Communicate with parents/guardians. Retrieved from http://www.worksheetlibrary.com/teachingtips/communicatewithparents.html

Potter, L., & Bulach, C. (2001). Do's and Don't of Parent-teacher Conferences. Education Digest, 66(9), 37-40.

J.M. Olds Collegiate. (n.d.). Roles and Responsibilities of School Council. Retrieved on: May 20, 2012, from: http://www.jmoc.ca/webdocs/Council%2520Roles.html.